

HOW COMMUNITIES CAN STOP DESTRUCTIVE DEVELOPMENT PROJECTS IN MALAWI

INTRODUCTION & FRAMEWORK

Malawi, though it remains one of the world's poorest countries, is a genuine multiparty democracy with working courts, a free press, and a notably strong and organised civil society — so the community here has real, open, and genuinely usable channels to turn to. At the heart of the country lies **Lake Malawi**, one of the great lakes of the African Rift Valley and one of the true natural wonders of the world: a vast inland freshwater sea holding more than a thousand distinct species of cichlid fish found nowhere else on the whole of the earth, a living laboratory of evolution often called the freshwater Galápagos of Africa, protected in significant part as a formal UNESCO World Heritage Site since 1984, and feeding some one and a half million people along its shores with more than half of the entire nation's protein. That great lake, and the forests of its watershed that keep it alive, now face real and pressing threats — above all the **exploration for oil and gas beneath the lake itself**, licensed across blocks that between them cover much of its open waters, but also the steady deforestation of the catchment that silts and fouls its waters, and the overfishing that is quietly emptying it. No threat here has been finally defeated. But in Malawi, unusually, the levers are real and can be used openly.

A community in Malawi defending the lake works with real, open tools, in a genuine democracy — and, unusually, can use them in the open. The distinctive lever is the lake's **World Heritage status and global scientific value**, which bring UNESCO, IUCN, and the world's protection to its defence. Malawi's **working courts and organised civil society** allow the lake to be defended openly, through law and public pressure; protest, petition, and litigation are lawful. The exploration and major projects must pass through **environmental impact assessment**, and the **transparency of the oil licensing** — blocks quietly granted over a World Heritage lake — is itself a powerful handle. The most distinctive argument is the **food-security and living-value case**: the lake feeds a nation, supplying more than half its protein to a million and a half people, and is worth far more alive, as fishery and heritage, than any oil beneath it. And the **world's conservation and transparency movements** stand ready to help. But these tools have real limits, and this guide states them plainly. Malawi is poor and energy-hungry, and the government sees oil as a path to development and revenue, so the pressure to drill is real. The deforestation is driven by poverty and the tobacco economy, and the overfishing by survival, so neither can be met by punishing the poor — only by alternatives and livelihoods. And no threat here has been finally defeated. So aim for what these tools can genuinely deliver — the oil exploration scrutinised, challenged, or refused; the World Heritage lake defended through its status and the courts; the catchment and fishery protected with alternatives, not bans — through the open courts, the civil society, the World Heritage system, and the argument that the lake is worth more alive than any oil beneath it.

The Whole Strategy in One Idea

You win here through the open channels a genuine democracy affords, anchored in the lake's global value. Invoke the World Heritage status that brings the world to the lake's defence; use the working courts and organised civil society to challenge the oil exploration openly; demand transparency of the licensing and rigour of the environmental assessment; and make the powerful argument that a lake feeding a nation and holding a thousand unique species is worth more alive than any oil beneath it. And meet the deforestation and overfishing with alternatives, never bans on the poor.

Be Honest About Which Fight You're In

Malawi is an open, hopeful setting — a genuine democracy with working courts, a free press, and a strong civil society, and a lake of global value. But honesty about the harder truths is the first discipline. The country is poor and energy-hungry, and the government sees oil as revenue; the deforestation is driven by poverty and tobacco, the overfishing by survival, so the poor cannot be punished; and no threat has been finally defeated. So aim at the winnable — the oil exploration scrutinised, challenged, or refused, the World Heritage lake defended, the catchment protected with alternatives — through the open courts, civil society, and the World Heritage system.

HOW THE SYSTEM WORKS

Who Actually Decides

A Malawian decision runs through a genuine, open democracy. The **government and its mines, energy, and environment bodies** grant the oil licences and permits and administer the assessments. The **working courts** review the legality, as Malawi's judiciary has shown it will. The **elected parliament** and a **free press** carry real accountability. The **organised civil society and conservation groups** act openly. And the **World Heritage system — UNESCO and IUCN** — and the international movements bring the world's protection. Map who decides the lake's fate before spending a week on it.

How a Project Moves — and Where You Jump In

The oil exploration proceeds under licences and must pass environmental assessment; other harms move through permits and the catchment. The assessment and the licensing are your first entry points: the moments to demand transparency, document the harm to a World Heritage lake, and press for scrutiny or refusal. Beyond them lie the courts, the civil society, and the World Heritage system. Enter early, openly, and anchored in the lake's global value and the food it provides.

Follow the Money and the Permissions

Follow the licences: who was granted the oil and gas blocks over the lake, on what terms, and with what transparency. Follow the assessment: whether the exploration's environmental study is adequate. Follow the food: what the lake provides — half a nation's protein — that the oil would risk. Follow the world: which World Heritage and conservation bodies stand with the lake. The leverage lies in the World Heritage status, the courts, the licensing transparency, and the living-value argument.

Who's Supposed to Be Watching

Malawi has real watchers, and they function: the environment and mines bodies, the working courts, the elected parliament, a free press, a strong and organised civil society, and — internationally — UNESCO, IUCN, and the conservation and transparency movements. These genuinely act, and a case is built to engage them, openly.

QUICK REFERENCE: SUCCESS RATES

Opposition in Malawi is genuinely possible and can be pursued openly, in a real democracy with a lake of global value. The single most decisive move is **anchoring the case in the lake's World Heritage status and its living value, and pursuing it through the open courts and civil society**, because a World Heritage lake feeding a nation commands the world's protection, and because Malawi's working courts and

organised civil society can act on it in the open. The World Heritage status is the distinctive lever; the courts and civil society the open means; the living-value argument the heart of the case; the international movements the reach. What the tools deliver is real — the oil exploration scrutinised, challenged, or refused, the lake defended — though no threat is finally beaten.

STEP 1: TARGET IDENTIFICATION

Ask five questions. **What is the harm?** — the oil and gas exploration beneath the lake, the catchment deforestation, the overfishing. **What does it need?** — a licence, an assessment, transparency. **What protects the lake?** — the World Heritage status, the environmental law. **What is the living value?** — the food, the fishery, the heritage the harm risks. **What drives the lesser harms?** — the poverty and tobacco behind the deforestation, requiring alternatives not bans. Pick the fight — above all the oil — where the World Heritage status and the courts bite hardest.

STEP 2: DOCUMENTATION

Build the case in layers. **Layer one: the harm** — the oil exploration's footprint and risk to the lake, the catchment loss, the emptying fishery, documented with the science. **Layer two: the status and the standard** — the World Heritage protection, the environmental-assessment requirements, the licensing terms and their transparency. **Layer three: the living value and the coalition** — the food and heritage the lake provides, and the courts, civil society, and World Heritage bodies to engage. A case anchored in the World Heritage status and the lake's living value, and carried openly through the courts and civil society, is one Malawi's institutions and the world take seriously.

WHAT TO GATHER, AND WHERE TO FIND IT

Gather the **harm record**: the oil licences and their footprint, the risk to the lake, the catchment deforestation, the fishery decline, the science. Gather the **status record**: the World Heritage listing, the environmental-assessment requirements, the licensing transparency. Gather the **living-value record**: the protein the lake supplies, the fishery, the thousand unique species, the heritage. Gather the **coalition record**: the courts, civil society, UNESCO, IUCN, the transparency movements. Malawi's open democracy and free press make much of this genuinely obtainable.

STEP 3: BUILDING LOCAL OPPOSITION

Malawi's strength is a strong, organised civil society that can act in the open. Build a coalition of the **lakeshore communities and fishers**, whose food and livelihood the lake is; the **conservation and civil-society organisations**, well organised and experienced; the **scientists** who can speak for the thousand unique species; the **legal advocates** who can bring the court challenges; and the **international World Heritage and transparency partners**. Frame the cause around the lake that feeds a nation and belongs to the world — and meet the deforestation and overfishing with alternatives and livelihoods, never blame on the poor who depend on them.

STEP 4: THE WORLD HERITAGE STATUS, THE COURTS & THE LIVING-VALUE ARGUMENT — DEFENDING THE LAKE

Set expectations honestly: here the levers are real and open, in a genuine democracy, though the pressure to drill is real.

The World Heritage Status and the International Movements

The distinctive lever is Lake Malawi's **World Heritage status and global scientific value**, which bring UNESCO, IUCN, and the world's conservation and transparency movements to its defence. Invoke the status and the world's protection against the oil beneath a World Heritage lake.

The Open Courts and the Assessment

Malawi's **working courts and organised civil society** allow the lake to be defended openly, and the exploration must pass **environmental impact assessment**, whose rigour and the **licensing transparency** are real handles. Challenge the assessment and the licences in the open, through law and public pressure.

The Living-Value Argument

The most distinctive argument is the **living value**: the lake feeds a nation with more than half its protein and holds a thousand species found nowhere else — worth far more alive than any oil beneath it. Pursued together — the World Heritage status, the open courts, and the living-value argument — these levers defend the lake, openly and with the world's help.

TURNING YOUR EVIDENCE INTO ARGUMENTS

Tailor the case to each audience. **For UNESCO and IUCN**: here is a World Heritage lake threatened by oil exploration beneath it. **For the courts**: here is a licence or assessment that breaches the law protecting the lake. **For the environment and mines bodies**: here is an inadequate assessment and an opaque licensing. **For the public and the fishers**: here is the lake that feeds us, worth more alive than any oil. **For the world's movements**: here is a global treasure needing transparency and protection. **The golden rule**: anchor the case in the World Heritage status and the living value, pursue it openly through the courts and civil society, demand transparency — and meet the poverty-driven harms with alternatives, not bans.

STEP 5: MEDIA STRATEGY

In an open democracy with a free press, media is a real weapon. Frame the story around **the lake that feeds a nation and belongs to the world**: a World Heritage treasure, a thousand unique species, half a nation's protein, threatened by oil beneath it. Carry it through the Malawian press, the civil-society networks, and the international conservation and transparency outlets. A few cautions: keep it accurate and anchored in the World Heritage status and the science; frame the deforestation and overfishing as matters for alternatives, not blame on the poor; and let the lake's living value and global standing carry the weight.

EMAILS & LETTERS

Keep every message factual, anchored in the World Heritage status and the living value, and just toward the poor.

8A — To UNESCO or IUCN: flag the oil exploration threatening the World Heritage lake and invoke its protection.

8B — To the courts (through counsel): establish the licence or assessment breach of the law protecting the lake.

8C — To the environment or mines body: challenge the inadequate assessment and demand licensing transparency.

8D — On the living value: set out the protein, the fishery, and the unique species the oil would risk.

8E — To a civil-society or conservation organisation: share the case and coordinate the open campaign.

8F — On the catchment and fishery: propose the alternatives and livelihoods that protect them without punishing the poor.

8G — To an international transparency movement: request scrutiny of the opaque oil licensing.

8H — To the press and public: dramatise the lake that feeds a nation and belongs to the world.

IF YOU HAVE LITTLE TIME OR FEW RESOURCES: THE RAPID-FIRE VERSION

The first 48 hours: pull the oil licences and their footprint over the lake; document the World Heritage status and the living value; write the one-page case. **The fastest-moving levers:** the World Heritage status, the open courts, and the licensing transparency. **Emergency action:** if the exploration is advancing, the World Heritage status, the environmental assessment, and — through counsel — the courts are the sharpest handles, and UNESCO and IUCN can be engaged at once. Throughout, anchor everything in the lake's global value and meet the poverty-driven harms with alternatives.

WHEN THE SYSTEM IS TILTED

Even in a genuine democracy the field can tilt: a poor, energy-hungry government that sees oil as revenue. Recognise it, and lean on the levers the tilt cannot escape — the World Heritage status and the world's protection, the working courts, the licensing transparency, and the living-value argument. In Malawi these genuinely work, in the open. And accept, honestly, that the pressure to drill is real, that the deforestation and overfishing are driven by poverty and must be met with alternatives not bans, and that no threat has been finally defeated — so the defence of the lake is a sustained, open effort.

WHEN IT'S ACTUAL CORRUPTION — AND WHO BENEFITS

Distinguish the ordinary tilt from capture — oil blocks over a World Heritage lake licensed opaquely, an assessment waved through, insiders benefiting. Where capture appears, respond through the open channels Malawi genuinely provides: the working courts, the free press, the organised civil society, the licensing transparency, and the international World Heritage and transparency movements. **On safety:** Malawi is a genuine democracy with working courts and a free press, so this work can be done openly and lawfully; the risks are political and economic, not the physical dangers of a closed state. Keep the work accurate, anchored in the World Heritage status and the living value, and just toward the poor.

INTEGRATION & TIMELINE

The steps run in parallel, and openly. The documented harm feeds the World Heritage appeal, the court challenge, and the transparency demand at once; the communities, civil society, and scientists organise

openly; the media dramatises the lake throughout; UNESCO and IUCN are engaged internationally. A rough timeline: **weeks one to four**, document the oil licences and the living value, and engage the environment body and civil society; **months two to six**, press the World Heritage status, the assessment, the transparency, and — through counsel — the courts, and engage UNESCO and IUCN; **beyond**, sustain the open defence of the lake. The core discipline: World Heritage-anchored, living-value-framed, pursued openly, and just toward the poor.

FINAL ASSESSMENT

Opposition in Malawi is genuinely possible and, unusually, open, because it is a real multiparty democracy with working courts, a free press, and a strong, organised civil society — defending a lake of global value. This guide has been honest that the country is poor and energy-hungry, that the government sees oil as a path to development and revenue, that the deforestation and overfishing are driven by poverty and survival and must be met with alternatives rather than bans on the poor, and that no threat has been finally defeated. But those honest truths do not weaken the effort — they define its shape. A community that anchors its case in Lake Malawi's World Heritage status and global scientific value, pursues it openly through the working courts and organised civil society, demands transparency of the oil licensing and rigour of the assessment, and makes the powerful argument that a lake feeding a nation and holding a thousand unique species is worth more alive than any oil beneath it can genuinely scrutinise, challenge, or refuse the exploration and defend the lake. The tools are real and can be used in the open, and the heart of the case is the freshwater Galápagos that feeds a nation and belongs to the world.